

Aunty Lit

Imagine an over-40 Bridget Jones struggling with CEO dinners and fantasising about the ex

| By Kaveree Barnzai |



THE GREAT DEPRESSION OF THE 40s
by RUPA GULAB
Penguin
Price: Rs 250
Pages: 215

Ever felt like an eternally-16-year-old-mean-girl who gets a start when she looks at the ageing face staring back at her in the mirror? Do you like rolling your eyes mentally every time you're in the company of a too-posh person? Or even feel congenitally compelled to always tell the truth? If you are, then Rupa Gulab's *The Great Depression of the 40s* is just for you. Forget the unfortunate mouthful of a title, or even the too-cute cover. This is a book that will make you laugh with its unvarnished "me too" moments. From the wannabe page 3 neighbour who is learning to sculpt mosaic, to the hostess with the mostest-sister-in-law who is in danger of falling for her ex;

from the Marathi Manooos driver who gives you a guilt trip to the calorie counting cholesterol hunting husband, there's something for every 40-something to giggle about—provided she can stretch her facial muscles far enough.

This is aunty lit at its best. Unpretentious, unspectacular prose, but also easy on the mind. Call it elevator literature, but sample this: "While the spaghetti was a bit of okay/The meatballs stubbornly bounced/They're only fit to be served at squash courts/And deserve to be severely trounced". Or this: "She seriously believed that drinking wine was a cultural accomplishment, on par with playing Mozart on the violin." Gulab, who also wrote *Girl Alone*, has a fine ear for the ridiculousness of the reluctant corporate wife-cum-journalist, Mantra: the discussions over what's better, the Atkins or the South Beach diet, or the senior office canteen boy moonlighting as the butler at the CEO's dinner. She also has a firm grip on the gamesmanship that constitutes urban life today: the stealing from hotel bathrooms of Raffles and Banyan Tree soapiers and the preening over limited edition pornographic DVDs. It does tend to sag a bit, as most 40-something bodies do, when it comes to the actual depression—the jobs that are awful, the sex life that can be static, the children who can be a constant headache when you have them and a terrible absence when you don't, the life threatening illness and also the obligatory wet towel bit. And okay, she does descend into the too precious territory occasionally by saying the waistline has become a vast-line and using expressions like luvrly, but hey, it's to be expected from a generation raised in the ditzzy disco age. How much sense can you expect, after all, from someone who knows the words to every Abba song ever sung? ■

TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. *2 States: The Story of My Marriage*
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
2. *The Immortals of Meluha*
Amish, Tara
3. *Dork: The Incredible Adventures of Robin 'Einstein' Varghese*
Sidin Vadukut, Penguin
4. *Oh Shit, Not Again!*
Mandar Kokate, Expression
5. *Devil in Pinstripes*
Ravi Subramanian, Rupa

NON-FICTION

1. *You can Sell*
Shiv Khera, Rupa
2. *Songs of Blood and Sword*
Fatima Bhutto, Viking
3. *The Difficulty of Being Good: On the Subtle Art of Dharma*
Gurcharan Das, Allen Lane
4. *Stay Hungry Stay Foolish*
Rashmi Bansal, CII, IIM-Ahmedabad
5. *Discover the Diamond in You*
Arindam Chaudhuri, Vikas

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

6. *The White Tiger*
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
8. *Empire of the Moghul: Raiders from the North*
Alex Rutherford, Hachette
9. *The Gamechangers*
The Fake IPL Player, HarperCollins

NON-FICTION

6. *Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight*
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
7. *Simply Fly: A Deccan Odyssey*
Captain Gopinath, Collins
8. *The Scientific Indian*
APJ Abdul Kalam and Y.S. Rajan, Penguin

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